

Morphological Creativity and Identity Expression in the Slang of LGBTQIA+ Thais in the Hiwwhee Gang

ความคิดสร้างสรรค์ด้านการสร้างคำและการแสดงอัตลักษณ์ในคำสแลง ของกลุ่มคนไทยที่มีความหลากหลายทางเพศในแก๊งหิ้วหิ้ว

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คำสำคัญ:

คำสแลงของกลุ่ม LGBTQIA+, ความคิดสร้างสรรค์ด้านการสร้างคำ, การสร้างคำ, วาทกรรมดิจิทัล, ภาษาศาสตร์, ภาษาเกย์

Abstract

Background and Objectives: The Thai LGBTQIA+ community has fostered a vibrant lexicon of slang that reflects its morphological creativity, identity expression, and popularity. A particularly influential force in this linguistic movement is the Hiwwhee Gang—a popular group of queer YouTubers with over five million followers—which plays a significant role in the creation, dissemination, and circulation of queer language in digital media. This study aims to identify and categorize the specific types of LGBTQIA+ slang used by the Hiwwhee Gang by analyzing how these expressions reflect the group's morphological creativity, construct group identity and signal in-group membership. It also examines how their use of slang facilitates audience engagement, and circulates and fosters a sense of inclusion within their online community.

Methods: The study adopts a qualitative linguistic approach, analyzing 34 slang items used in the Hiwwhee Gang's YouTube content. These were categorized according to word formation processes, including blending, compounding, clipping, borrowing, onomatopoeia, and semantic shift, together with an analysis of frequency, the motivations underlying word formation, and the sociocultural contexts of slang use among LGBTQIA+ communities, using the Hiwwhee Gang as a case study.

Results: Thai LGBTQIA+ slang is notable for its creative use of lexical blending, sound imitation, and phonological play to produce humorous effects. While blending and compounding are common in the Gang's slang, ideophones and performative speech acts, suggesting the group members' behavior, actions, or values via slang, such as *สะดุ้ง* (*sa dung* or startled) or *เซตุมเล้ง* (*se tum leng* or chaotic), pointing to the discourse-stylistic nature of queer conversation. Likewise, semantic shifts are notable, as terms like *ขมวด* (*khamuat* or to wrap) and *ฉ่ำ* (*cham* or juicy) take on entirely new meanings in different context. These linguistic innovations not only offer humor and identity performance but also resist mainstream discourse and play an important role in resisting heteronormative ideology by generating linguistic forms that challenge conventional word structures and traditional meaning-making processes.

Application of this study: The findings are valuable for scholars in linguistics, gender studies, and digital media. Educators and language policy designers may also apply these insights to better accommodate linguistic diversity in designing curriculums which respect linguistic diversity. Moreover, the research also promotes the preservation and elevation of queer vernaculars as culturally significant linguistic forms.

Conclusions: The use of slang among the Thai LGBTQIA+ community functions as a tool for identity construction, community boundary formation, and the creation of spaces for social participation through language. When queer speakers reinterpret existing lexical items and move beyond conventional linguistic and semantic frameworks of the dominant language, a culturally specific language emerges that enables presence, visibility, and solidarity. The findings further indicate that creativity in word formation plays a crucial role both as a cultural tool and as a strategy for resisting mainstream social structures in contemporary Thai society.

บทคัดย่อ

ที่มาและวัตถุประสงค์: กลุ่มผู้มีความหลากหลายทางเพศในประเทศไทย (LGBTQIA+) ได้พัฒนาคำสแลงที่มีลักษณะเฉพาะตัวโดดเด่นและสะท้อนถึงความคิดสร้างสรรค์ในการสร้างคำใหม่ การแสดงออกด้านอัตลักษณ์ และความนิยมของการใช้คำสแลง โดยเฉพาะอย่างยิ่ง “แก๊งหิ้วหิ้ว” กลุ่มยูทูบเบอร์ที่มีผู้ติดตามรวมกันมากกว่าห้าล้านคน ซึ่งมีบทบาทสำคัญ

ในการสร้างสรรค์ เผยแพร่ และทำให้ภาษาเกย์แพร่หลายในสื่อดิจิทัล งานวิจัยนี้มีจุดมุ่งหมายเพื่อระบุและจัดประเภทคำสแลงของกลุ่มคนไทยที่มีความหลากหลายทางเพศ หรือ กลุ่ม LGBTQIA+ ที่แก๊งหิ้วหวีใช้ โดยวิเคราะห์ว่าคำสแลงเหล่านี้สะท้อนความคิดสร้างสรรค์ทางการสร้างคำอย่างไร มีบทบาทในการสร้างอัตลักษณ์ของกลุ่มและแสดงความเป็นสมาชิกภายในกลุ่มอย่างไร และศึกษาการใช้คำสแลงของกลุ่มหิ้วหวีในการเสริมสร้างการมีส่วนร่วมของผู้ชม เกิดการแพร่หลาย และสร้างความรู้สึกร่วมเป็นส่วนหนึ่งในชุมชนออนไลน์

วิธีการศึกษา: งานวิจัยใช้ระเบียบวิธีวิเคราะห์ภาษาศาสตร์เชิงคุณภาพด้วยศึกษาคำสแลงจำนวน 34 รายการจากเนื้อหาของช่อง YouTube ของแก๊งหิ้วหวี ผู้วิจัยจำแนกคำสแลงตามกระบวนการสร้างคำ เช่น การผสมคำ การประสมคำ การตัดคำ การยืมคำ การใช้คำเลียนเสียง และการเปลี่ยนความหมายของคำเดิม พร้อมวิเคราะห์ความถี่ เหตุผลที่มาของการสร้างคำ บริบททางสังคมวัฒนธรรมของการใช้งานของคำสแลงของชาว LGBTQIA+ โดยใช้แก๊งหิ้วหวีเป็นกรณีศึกษา

ผลการศึกษา: คำสแลงของชาว LGBTQIA+ ไทยมีลักษณะเด่นที่ความคิดสร้างสรรค์ด้านการผสมคำใหม่ การสร้างคำเลียนเสียง และการเล่นเสียงเพื่อสร้างอารมณ์ขัน ขณะที่การผสมคำและการสร้างคำจากการประสมพบได้ทั่วไปในสแลงของแก๊งหิ้วหวี คำเลียนเสียง และการแสดงออกเชิงกายภาพ ซึ่งแสดงถึงพฤติกรรม การกระทำ หรือค่านิยมของสมาชิกในกลุ่มหิ้วหวีผ่านคำสแลง เช่นคำ สะตุง และ เซะตุมเล้ง ซึ่งให้เห็นถึงธรรมชาติด้านวจนลีลาของการสนทนาแบบเกย์รียก เช่นเดียวกัน การปรับหรือเปลี่ยนความหมายคำเดิมเป็นรูปแบบการสร้างคำสแลงที่พบเจอได้มาก เช่นคำ ขมวด และ น้ำ ซึ่งมีความหมายใหม่ในบริบทที่แตกต่างจากเดิม ประติษฐานทางภาษาเช่นนี้ไม่เพียงแต่แสดงถึงมอริมทัศน์และการแสดงออกทางอัตลักษณ์ แต่ต่อต้านวาทกรรมกระแสหลัก และมีบทบาทสำคัญในการต้านทานอุดมการณ์แบบเอเทอโรนอร์มผ่านการสร้างภาษาที่ไม่อยู่ในกรอบโครงสร้างคำหรือการสร้างควมหมายแบบเดิม

การประยุกต์ใช้: ผลการวิจัยเป็นประโยชน์ต่อนักวิชาการและนักวิจัยด้านภาษาศาสตร์ การศึกษาความหลากหลายทางเพศ และสื่อดิจิทัล นักการศึกษาและผู้ออกแบบนโยบายทางภาษา อาจพิจารณาประยุกต์ใช้แง่มุมเชิงลึกเพื่อออกแบบหลักสูตรที่เคารพต่อความหลากหลายทางภาษา นอกจากนี้ งานวิจัยยังส่งเสริมการรักษาและยกระดับภาษาเฉพาะถิ่นเกย์รียกให้เป็นรูปแบบทางภาษาที่มีความสำคัญด้านวัฒนธรรม

บทสรุป: การใช้คำสแลงของกลุ่ม LGBTQIA+ ไทยถือเป็นเครื่องมือในการสร้างอัตลักษณ์ สร้างขอบเขตชุมชน และสร้างพื้นที่ในการมีส่วนร่วมทางสังคมผ่านภาษา เมื่อผู้พูดภาษาเกย์รียกตีความคำเดิมใหม่และก้าวข้ามกรอบทางภาษาและความหมายแบบเดิมในภาษาหลัก ภาษาเฉพาะกลุ่มวัฒนธรรมซึ่งเอื้อให้เกิดการมีตัวตน การมองเห็น และความเป็นปึกแผ่นจะเกิดขึ้น ผลการวิจัยยังชี้ให้เห็นว่าความคิดสร้างสรรค์ทางการสร้างคำมีบทบาทสำคัญทั้งในฐานะเครื่องมือทางวัฒนธรรมและกลยุทธ์ในการต้านทานโครงสร้างสังคมกระแสหลักในสังคมร่วมสมัยของประเทศไทย

Introduction

LGBTQIA+ is an acronym representing lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, queer (or questioning), intersex, and asexual individuals, encompassing a broad spectrum of gender identities and sexual orientations as observed by Jackson (2009), with a “+” plus sign denoting other possible sexual orientations and gender identities that are not listed. In Thailand, the Hiwwhee Gang has emerged as a highly influential collective of LGBTQIA+ digital content creators, significantly shaping cultural discourse in entertainment and fashion. Recently, Vogue Thailand (2024) reported that the group’s influence is evident in the success of their YouTube channel, and reaffirms their strong presence in both LGBTQIA+ and mainstream Thai digital communities.

The Hiwwhee Gang (หิ้วหวี, literally translated as carrying a bunch of bananas [to different places], and originated from a local popular gibberish song) initially began as a small, close-knit group consisting of five core members—Nutt Nisamanee, Eclair Juepak, Alie Blackcobra, Mix Chaleomsri, and Erk Charrissa. Over time, their dynamic personalities, combined with their distinctive linguistic styles, have positioned them as key cultural figures within Thailand’s LGBTQIA+ community. Their signature slang and expressive communication styles serve as powerful markers of identity. Furthermore, while these five individuals form the group’s core, Sanitdee (2023) noted that their influence extends beyond their immediate circle, as they frequently collaborate with other LGBTQIA+ influencers, further amplifying their impact.

In addition to their collective presence, each Hiwwhee Gang member has established a strong individual digital footprint, attracting millions of followers across various platforms. Each member commands a substantial online following, with some of their channels exceeding two million subscribers (Nisamanee, 2025). Beyond the 5 core members, the group

has continuously expanded through collaborations with other digital creators, such as Fluk Karon (“Fluk” the cunning), the creator behind Lok Khong Khon Mee Nuad or “the world of people with moustache” (1.4 million followers), along with various LGBTQIA+ influencers and mainstream Thai celebrities. These collaborations have reinforced the Hiwwhee Gang’s position as a leading force in Thailand’s LGBTQIA+ digital culture.



Figure 1 The Hiwwhee Friends
(Source: Sabudpraeng Facebook page, 2024)

One of the Hiwwhee’s defining features and successes is their distinct use of slang, which plays a crucial role in shaping community identity, cultural representation, and group cohesion. Linguistic innovation has long been an integral part of LGBTQIA+ expression, allowing individuals to articulate their experiences in ways that mainstream language often fails to capture. Particularly, the unique vocabulary popularized by the Hiwwhee Gang encapsulates shared experiences, emotions, and cultural narratives, reflecting both creativity and resistance against traditional linguistic norms. Kanchanabundhu & Trakulkasemsuk (2022) acknowledged that Thai LGBTQIA+ communities have developed their own expressive lexicon—often referred to as “LGBT terms”—which serves both as an in-group communication tool and as a medium for playful, humorous, and exaggerated self-expression. Importantly, many of these linguistic innovations have transcended their original social contexts, gradually integrating into mainstream Thai language and influencing broader societal discourse.

Given the Hiwwhee Gang’s morphological creativity and cultural significance, this study seeks to investigate the types and functions of LGBTQIA+ slang used within their digital contents, and how each slang word is coined and formed morphologically. Specifically, the research aims to explore how these linguistic expressions found in slang contribute to community identity formation, self-representation, and the reinforcement of social belonging. By examining the interplay between digital media, linguistic innovation, and LGBTQIA+ identity, this research aims to (1) identify the dominant word-formation processes found in the Hiwwhee Gang’s commonly used slang and (2) examine the sociolinguistic functions these processes serve in shaping humorous, expressive, and identity-marking discourse within the group’s digital interactions.

Current studies on Thai LGBTQIA+ linguistic practices acknowledge the existence of queer lexicons but have not specifically examined the Hiwwhee Gang—one of Thailand’s most influential LGBTQIA+ digital groups—whose creative slang, mass visibility, and cross-platform influence have reshaped both queer and mainstream discourse. While prior research has discussed LGBTQIA+ language in general terms, it has not addressed how digital influencers actively

generate, circulate, and normalize such slang in contemporary Thai media culture. This study fills the gap by analyzing the distinct types and communicative functions of the Hiwwhee Gang's slang, demonstrating how their linguistic innovation contributes to identity construction, social belonging, and broader cultural shifts.

Literature Review

1. Slang

Slang is a dynamic and informal subset of language that emerges within specific social groups as a means of fostering identity, solidarity, and exclusivity. To Rezeki & Sagala (2019), it is characterized by non-standard vocabulary, novel expressions, and creative linguistic adaptations, often deviating from formal grammar and meaning. Sociolinguists, including Jannah (2023), emphasize that slang serves both individual and collective purposes, reflecting cultural trends, group affiliation, and resistance to mainstream linguistic norms.

From a sociolinguistic perspective, slang is deeply intertwined with social identity and community formation. This is because language use is influenced by various sociodemographic factors, including age, gender, class, and cultural background (Jannah, 2023). On the one hand, the formation of slang follows recognizable morphological processes, such as derivation, compounding, blending, and borrowing, allowing it to evolve in response to social and technological changes. On the other hand, media and digital communication platforms have significantly accelerated the spread of slang, introducing terms that quickly gain widespread adoption. For instance, in Kopaczyk's study (2014), expressions like "YOLO" (You Only Live Once) and "lit" (meaning exciting or great) exemplify how digital culture influences contemporary English slang.

Beyond its linguistic formation, slang serves multiple functions in communication. According to Ryanto (2022), one key function is self-identity, where individuals use slang to feel connected and accepted within their community, fostering a sense of group belonging. Slang also allows speakers to express emotions, providing an outlet for stress, humor, and informal interaction. Additionally, slang helps achieve politeness by maintaining a friendly and relaxed tone, making conversations more approachable and engaging. While politeness theory suggests that speakers may use slang to reduce conflict and maintain smooth social interaction through strategies such as giving options and making listeners feel good (Lakoff, 1973), Allan & Burridge (2006) view slang as serving multiple functions—including identity expression, emotional expression, and group cohesion—without strict adherence to standard language norms. These functions illustrate slang's role in shaping both personal and social interactions, reinforcing identity, emotional expression, and community cohesion (Wihadi, Pratiwi, & Rahmatunnisa, 2020).

Although slang shares some similarities with other non-standard linguistic forms, it differs significantly from pidgin, creole, and jargon—terms that many non-linguists often confuse. Williams (2024) generally concludes that pidgin languages emerge as simplified communication systems between speakers of different native languages (superstrate vs. substrate languages), often in trade or colonial settings, and lack the complexity of fully developed languages. Over time, some pidgins evolve into creoles (a full-fledged language), which develop stable grammatical structures and become native languages within a community (Williams, 2024). In contrast, jargon consists of technical or specialized terms used within professional or academic fields, such as the terms cytokine in biology, or in hermeneutics in humanities. Williams further explains that while jargon facilitates precise communication, it can also act as a linguistic barrier, excluding those unfamiliar with the terminology.

As highlighted by Ryanto (2022), and Allan & Burridge (2006), slang plays a crucial role in communication by reinforcing social identity and emotional expression. However, while these social and emotional functions are fundamental

to slang usage, our research focuses on the structural aspects of slang, particularly word formation processes within Thai LGBTQIA+ communities. By uncovering the creative linguistic mechanisms that shape slang expressions, this study aims to provide a more detailed understanding on morphological creativity, identity construction and slang circulation of the Hiwwhee Gang, a Thai LGBTQIA+ group.

2. Word Formation Processes

Word formation is a fundamental aspect of morphology, the study of how words are structured and created. It plays a crucial role in linguistic evolution, enabling languages to adapt to social and cultural changes. Wan Mohd Muzani & Mohammad Lotfie (2024) recognized that this process is closely linked to neologism or coinage, the creation of new words, which can arise from entirely new roots or modifications of existing words using specific morphological processes. Xerox and Kodak are coinage brand name word samples used to refer to any other related words or similar brands of copy machines and cameras, respectively. Scholars like Yahya and Ardi (2023) have identified multiple methods of word formation, including affixation, compounding, blending, conversion, clipping, borrowing, backformation, acronyms, reduplication, semantic shift, and creative respelling. These processes allow for the continual expansion of vocabulary across languages and dialects.

One of the most common word formation processes is compounding, where two or more words combine to create a new term (Yule, 2010), such as “notebook” or “laptop.” Another similar process called blending involves merging parts of words, like “brunch” (from breakfast + lunch). Affixation, on the other hand, refers to the addition of prefixes or suffixes to modify meaning, as in “unhappy” or “modernize.” Similarly, acronyms, abbreviation and initialisms simplify longer phrases, such as “ASAP” (as soon as possible). Other processes, such as clipping (e.g., “exam” from “examination” or “edit” from “editor”, a final or back clipping, backformation or apocope), show how language economizes speech for efficiency. Conversely, in terms of meaning change from similar word base forms, semantic shift occurs when existing words develop new meanings in different contexts, reflecting changes in societal values and usage, according to Wan Mohd Muzani & Mohammad Lotfie (2024) and Hinton, Nichols & Ohala (1994).

Another key word formation process is onomatopoeia, where words imitate natural sounds. According to Ma (2018), this process plays a bridging role between early sound-based communication and more developed language systems. This process is particularly relevant in early language development and continues to influence modern lexicons. Onomatopoeic words often adapt to linguistic structures while retaining their phonetic essence, demonstrating their ability to evolve alongside language. Examples of onomatopoeic words include “buzz”, “sizzle”, “clang”, “woof”, and “meow”, all of which mimic the sounds they represent. These words not only enhance expressive communication but also illustrate how language naturally integrates auditory experiences into its vocabulary.

Word formation processes are also evident in LGBTQIA+ colloquial language, as explored by Sanitdee (2023). Her study on Thai LGBTQIA+ slang features phonological modifications and pragmatic-semantic shifts, showing how certain words take on new, community-specific meanings. These shifts align with broader linguistic trends, where groups repurpose existing words to create inclusive, expressive, and identity-affirming language. Similarly, the study by Unthanon, Chanthao and Dandee (2024) supports the adaptability of formal Thai vocabulary through processes such as compounding, borrowing, and affixation, underscoring the universal nature of word formation.

These studies illustrate how morphological processes drive linguistic innovation, shaping language in response to social identity, cultural shifts, and communication needs. By examining the overlapping yet distinct mechanisms of word formation in both formal and informal Thai, as well as in LGBTQIA+ slang, researchers and readers gain a deeper understanding of how language functions as both a reflection of society and a tool for adaptation.

Theoretical Framework

In this research study, we integrate the frameworks of Wan Mohd Muzani & Mohammad Lotfie (2024) and Yahya & Ardi (2023), who classify different methods of word creation. Wan Mohd Muzani & Mohammad Lotfie (2024) identifies eight primary processes: affixation, compounding, conversion, shortening, sound imitation, reduplication, creative respelling, and semantic shift. Meanwhile, Yahya & Ardi (2023) expand upon these categories by outlining ten key methods: coinage, borrowing, compounding, blending, clipping, backformation, conversion, acronyms, derivation, and hybrid formations combining multiple processes. Together, these classifications provide a comprehensive framework for examining how linguistic innovation occurs within specific communities, particularly in informal and expressive registers such as slang.

One of the most direct methods of word formation is coinage, which refers to the creation of entirely new words without deriving them from existing linguistic elements (Anggraeni, 2011). Many coined words originate in branding and product naming, later becoming widely adopted in general language use. Another practical process is compounding, where two or more independent words are combined to form a new lexical unit, such as *football* (a closed compound), *high school* (an open compound), or *check-in* (a hyphenated compound) (Fitria, 2022). This method is frequently observed across languages, contributing to a vast range of new vocabulary.

Closely related to compounding is blending, which involves merging parts of two words, usually by taking the beginning of one word and the end of another (Anggraeni, 2011). This process is commonly used in modern slang, as seen in words like “brunch” (from breakfast and lunch) and “motel” (from motor and hotel). A different but similarly concise process is clipping, where a longer word is shortened without altering its meaning (Fitria, 2022). Common examples include “ad” from advertisement and “bro” from brother.

Acronyms and initialisms also represent a common strategy for creating new words. As noted by Fitria (2022), acronyms are formed by combining the first letters of a phrase and pronouncing them as a single word—for example, “COD” for “Cash on Delivery.” In contrast, initialisms retain the individual pronunciation of each letter, as in “PO” (Pre-Order). Both processes are widely used in digital communication and commercial terminology, displaying the efficiency-driven nature of modern slang formation.

Other processes involve more subtle linguistic transformations. Conversion, assigns an existing word to a different syntactic category without altering its form (Anggraeni, 2011). For example, a noun can function as a verb, as in “nail” (noun) → “to nail” (verb). Similarly, affixation modifies a base word by adding prefixes or suffixes, creating new meanings while maintaining a recognizable root (Fitria, 2022). For example, the prefix “re-” in “restock” or the suffix “-er” in “reseller” show how affixation extends word utility.

In a more phonologically driven category, sound imitation, sound symbolism or onomatopoeia plays a role in shaping vocabulary. According to Ma (2018), onomatopoeic words originate from natural sounds and exhibit characteristics such as adaptation, lexical influence, interaction, and structural imitation. These words often reflect sensory experiences, making them a crucial component in expressive and emotive slang.

Beyond these structural processes, words also undergo semantic shifts, where meanings change due to cultural or contextual influences. Khalid (2019) identified key types of semantic shifts, including broadening (e.g., “holiday” originally meant a religious festival but now refers to any vacation), narrowing (e.g., “girl” once meant a young person of any gender but now refers specifically to females), amelioration (where a word gains a more positive meaning), and pejoration (where a word takes on a negative connotation). These shifts reflect how language adapts to societal

transformations, particularly in slang, where words frequently acquire new, context-dependent meanings (Brown, 2015; Asri et al., 2024).

Finally, borrowing plays a significant role in linguistic innovation in the globalized world, particularly when words from foreign languages are integrated and adapted to the phonetic or morphological structures of the borrowing language (Anggraeni, 2011). This process reflects both cultural exchange and linguistic necessity, as seen in terms like “croissant” from French or “yogurt” from Turkish.

By utilizing these word formation processes as illustrated in the tree diagram in Figure 3, this study provides a structured framework for analyzing how Thai LGBTQIA+ slang develops through morphological creativity and sociolinguistic influences. While some of these methods are universally observed across languages, we hypothesize that unique modifications and cultural adaptations shape Thai LGBTQIA+ slang in distinct ways. The investigation aims to uncover both shared linguistic patterns and community-specific innovations, offering insights into how language serves as a tool for identity expression and social belonging.

Research Methods

A qualitative and quantitative linguistic analysis helps examine the word formation processes found in the Hiwwhee Gang's slang terms. The qualitative analysis focuses on the structural and functional aspects of slang, revealing how language is creatively adapted within the Thai LGBTQIA+ community. Meanwhile, the quantitative analysis provides an overview of the distribution and frequency of these linguistic phenomena within this specific context.

1. Data Collection

The primary data for this research study were collected from the Hiwwhee Gang's digital content (originating in 2017), specifically from their YouTube channels launched from January 1st, 2024 to June 30th, 2025. The group consists of well-known Thai LGBTQIA+ influencers who frequently use distinctive slang in their speech. The selected content includes videos from the following creators, with their YouTube channel names in parentheses (some channel names are originally written in Thai): 1) Nutt Nisamanee (NisamaneeNutt), 2) Mix Chaleomsri (เฉลิมศรี [Chaleomsri]), 3) Alie Blackcobra (Alie Blackcobra), 4) Erk Charrissa (Chrrissa Chotijirasathit), 5) Eclair Juepak (Juepak), and, 6) Fluk Karon (โลกของคนมีหนวด [The World of People with Mustaches]).

2. Data Selection Criteria

To ensure relevance and consistency, these criteria were used in selecting slang from the content:

1) Frequency of usage—Only slang terms that appear multiple times across different videos or speakers are analyzed.

2) Originality—The majority of slang terms used by the Hiwwhee Gang are coined within their community. However, as with many dialects, jargons, and non-standard language variations, some of their slang expressions cannot always be etymologically traced or attributed solely to their innovation. Nonetheless, whenever possible, the etymological background of these slang terms was provided to ensure a comprehensive linguistic analysis.

3) Linguistic innovation—The focus was on words that demonstrate creative word formation rather than standard informal speech.

4) Community relevance—Slang terms must be specific to the Hiwwhee Gang and reflect LGBTQIA+ identity rather than general Thai slang.

5) Contextual clarity—Words and phrases must be used in a clear conversational context, allowing for accurate interpretation.

Based on the initial lexical screening, 47 slang word tokens were identified. However, following reanalysis, theoretical categorization, and consultation with linguistic experts, a final set of 34 slang terms was selected for analysis. These gained data were analyzed using morphological and functional analyses.

3. Justification for Data Source

The Hiwwhee Gang was selected as the primary data source because, first and foremost, they constitute one of Thailand's most influential LGBTQIA+ digital collectives, whose linguistic expressions are widely circulated, imitated, and commercialized. Consequently, their language practices directly align with this study's central aim of examining contemporary LGBTQIA+ slang in digital culture. Moreover, their exceptionally high visibility—reflected in a following of more than five million across social media platforms—ensures a consistently rich supply of innovative slang, thereby providing a prolific site for identifying active word-formation processes. In addition, because all their content is publicly accessible on YouTube, the dataset poses no ethical complications and, furthermore, enables transparent verification and replicability for future researchers.

4. Data Analysis

4.1 Morphological Analysis

Slang terms were classified based on the word formation processes identified in previous linguistic studies (Wan Mohd Muzani & Mohammad Lotfie, 2024; Yahya & Ardi, 2023). The following processes are used for categorization: 1) coinage, 2) compounding, 3) conversion, 4) clipping, 5) acronyms, 6) blending, 7) affixation, 8) borrowing, 9) sound imitation and 10) semantic shift. The quantitative analysis through the frequency of occurrences was also presented.

4.2 Functional Analysis

Beyond structure, the functions of slang within the community were also examined. Using the frameworks of Ryanto (2022) and Allan & Burridge (2006), the slang terms were analyzed based on their role in 1) emotional expression, 2) self-identity, and 3) social bonding.

5. Justification for the Analytical Framework

The combined frameworks of Wan Mohd Muzani & Mohammad Lotfie (2024) and of Yahya & Ardi (2023) were employed because, collectively, these models offer comprehensive coverage of traditional, digital, and sociolect-specific morphological processes essential for analyzing contemporary Thai LGBTQIA+ slang. Moreover, this integrated framework is particularly suited to multilingual and hybrid linguistic environments, especially given that Thai LGBTQIA+ slang frequently incorporates Thai, English, *Lu* language, Japanese, and a range of ideophonic forms; therefore, its capacity to account for borrowing, coinage, blending, reduplication, creative respelling, semantic shift, and onomatopoeia makes it exceptionally appropriate. Additionally, the framework aligned well with qualitative sociolinguistic inquiry, not only facilitating both structural and pragmatic analysis but also supporting the study's dual emphasis on morphological creativity and identity construction.

6. Research Validity and Ethical Considerations

To ensure accuracy and credibility, data verification was conducted through cross-referencing with multiple YouTube videos to confirm word usage and meanings. Consultation with native speakers, linguists and LGBTQIA+ community members to ensure that interpretations align with actual usage was also provided. Additionally, all data collection complies with ethical guidelines for research. No personal or sensitive information was collected, encoded, or analyzed; all content comes from publicly available sources on YouTube.

As this study adopts a case-study approach focused on a single Thai LGBTQIA+ digital community within a limited time frame, the findings are inherently context-specific. Consequently, the results reflect linguistic practices unique to the particular social, temporal, and media environment examined and should not be generalized as representative of Thai LGBTQIA+ communities more broadly or of slang usage across different contexts.

Research Results

The quantitative analysis of 96 YouTube videos (January 1st, 2024 to June 30th, 2025) of over 60 hours identified 34 slang terms, coined and used by the Hiwwhee Gang. Semantic shift is the most frequent process (22.94%), indicating a strong preference for reassigning meanings to existing words. Borrowing (11.76%) reflects external linguistic influence, whereas clipping (8.82 %) suggests a fast-paced lifestyle. Less common processes include compounding, conversion, coinage, and onomatopoeia, each at 5.88%, often requiring cultural familiarity or creative phonology. The least frequent is euphemism (2.94 %), suggesting Thai cultural norms of politeness while neither affixation nor blending was found. Overall, the data display diverse and context-driven lexical innovation within Thai LGBTQIA+ digital discourse. A comparative frequency of word formation processes is presented in Table 1 below, also grouped by their linguistic, social, and cultural influences, or factors.

Table 1 Frequency of Slang Word Types Used by the Hiwwhee Gang

Types of Slang Word Formation Process		Frequency (Percentage)
Semantic shift	<i>Meaning factor</i>	18 (52.94 %)
Borrowing	} <i>Foreignization factor</i>	4 (11.76 %)
Clipping		3 (8.82 %)
Compounding		2 (5.88 %)
Conversion		2 (5.88 %)
Coinage	} <i>Cultural factor</i>	2 (5.88 %)
Onomatopoeia		2 (5.88 %)
Euphemism		1 (2.96%)
Total number		34 (100 %)

The overlapping nature of word formation process categories, as noted in Table 2 below, reflects the lexical complexity of slang word formation. Most words, such as those categorized as "semantic shift + onomatopoeia," embody double word formation method, contributing to their dynamic use within the community, and suggesting the Hiwwhee community members’ conscious and subconscious thoughtfulness. In addition to the double word formation method,

multiple or complex word formation method found in each of the slang words is frequent. For example, a word can be created by means of coinage in a foreign language first, then it is borrowed and brought to Thai language, and is finally clipped (Gatsby → *gat* → *gas* [spelled as “gas” as in its orthographic form “แก๊ส” in Thai]). There are also several slang terms constructed by only one single word formation method. These linguistic phenomena indicate morphological manipulation and innovation of the Gang.

Each of the 34 slang terms appears repeatedly across several videos, ensuring that only stable and widely used expressions are included. This number also covers all major word-formation processes found in the Hiwwhee Gang’s slang, providing a complete and representative sample for this qualitative case study analysis. Most importantly, with the qualitative linguistic research nature, these 34 terms offer variation and clear contextual usage to allow for rigorous examination of the group’s morphological creativity.

Table 2 Lexical Complexity of the Slang Terms

Types of Slang Word Formation Process	Frequency (Percentage)
Double word formation method	14 (41.17 %)
Complex word formation method	11 (32.35 %)
Single word formation method	9 (26.48 %)
Total number	34 (100 %)

Thematic discussions, organized in terms of the slang categories and their discourse functions, are presented in the subsections following this introduction to the findings and discussion. For clarity and consistency, the following coding system is employed for all data samples. First, each Hiwwhee slang term is presented in Thai script. Second, its romanization—italicized in parentheses—follows, based on the most recent version (1.5.2) of the Thai Romanization software developed by Chulalongkorn University (Aroonmanakun & Rivepiboon, 2014). This system adheres to the transcription-based romanization principles of the Royal Institute, updated as of July 2014. The non-toned Thai simple transcriptions here are provided for ease of reading, minimal style and further reference. Widely used as a standard and accessible tool for romanization and transcription, it is not intended exclusively for phonetic representation. Third, an English equivalent is provided in descriptive form, and sometimes in square brackets when explained. Where relevant, key slang terms are examined using interlinear glossing and idiomatic English translation to help explain their meanings and how they are used in context. The full system is as follows:

(0. [example])	ชีวิตแลกชีวิต	→	Hiwwhee slang in Thai
	<i>chiwit laek chiwit</i>	→	<i>Thai romanization transcription</i>
	(life exchange life)	→	(gloss translation)
	[Life for life]	→	[English translation]

However, given the structural and grammatical differences between Thai and English—and considering that this study does not aim to provide a comprehensive account of Thai syntax—detailed explanations of Thai grammatical rules are omitted. This omission includes, for instance, the classification, meanings, and pragmatic functions of Thai particles which are prevalent in colloquial usage (abbreviated as “PART” [with particle subtypes for politeness markers abbreviated “POL”, and, for allowance “ALLOW”, superscripted]). Different forms of negation are all abbreviated as “NEG”, question

markers “Q”, and passive forms “PAS”. Consequently, gloss translations are presented in a non-agreeing English format, reflecting a direct, morpheme-by-morpheme rendering from Thai into English, without adjustments for person or number agreement to enable readers to see traces of the original Thai expressions. Basic meanings of Thai words and their slang equivalents in this research article are referenced according to the first and second definitions listed in the Royal Institute Dictionary (2013). The researchers attempted to include as many glosses, but since most terms do not have a single unit equivalence, this approach proved even more perplexing for readers. Additionally, as the main focus is on the morphological creativity or word formation and etymological investigation in certain word tokens, the researchers opted to generally provide translation ideas to give readers an overview of the selected LGBTQIA+ slang case study.

1. Morphological Creativity

1.1 Semantic Shift: Expectable VS Unexpected Meaning Reassignments

The majority of the Hiwwhee Gang slang terms are processed by means of semantic shift, involving partial or complete alterations of the original meanings of standard Thai lexemes. Some of these slang expressions remain partially transparent to general Thai speakers, as their phonological forms and semantic associations are not entirely opaque. For instance, (1) คุณน้า (*khun na* [polite addressing marker + a mother’s younger sister]), which conventionally denotes “mother’s younger sister,” has undergone semantic reanalysis. It is now employed playfully by the Hiwwhee to address or refer to prominent LGBTQIA+ individuals who embody boldness or fierceness. This usage functions as a term of endearment, expressing both respect and admiration. A common example is the greeting “สวัสดีค่ะ คุณน้า” (*sawatdi kha khun na* [good morning, auntie]), used colloquially to say hello. Similarly, another easy-to-guess phrase ชีวิตแลกชีวิต (*chee vit leak chee vit* [life for life])—literally “life for life”—has been pragmatically extended in contemporary slang. Frequently employed by Erk Chalisa, it carries a positively connoted, metaphorically used in specific contexts, as illustrated below.

2a) Erk: พรุ่งนี้ก็ต้องมาอยู่แล้ว อันนี้ไม่ต้องพูดเลย

phrungni ko tong ma yu laeo an ni mai tong phut loei

(tomorrow PART must come surely this NEG must speak PART)

Tomorrow I will be right back. You don’t have to ask.

2b) Month: แต่ว่าชีวิตแลกชีวิตก็จะหมดสิ้นแล้วนะ

taewa chiwit laek chiwit ko cha motsin laeo na

(but life exchange life PART will end already PART)

But our “life for life” moment is going to end soon.

(Fluk Karon, 2024)

In this excerpt, the speaker Erk uses the phrase ชีวิตแลกชีวิต (*chee vit leak chee vit*) in a light-hearted way to persuade Month to extend their time together. While the phrase literally means “life for life,” it is reinterpreted here to express strong emotional connection and a wish to stay longer as if parting would be the end of the world. This example illustrates how literal expressions can undergo semantic shift and be recontextualized to fulfill interpersonal and pragmatic functions in casual conversation.

1.2 Semantic Shift as Verbal Irony

Semantic shift within the Hiwwhee Gang slang often includes ironic reversal, wherein originally positive expressions acquire negative connotations and vice versa. For example, the term (3) เร็ดปะ (*red pa* [fabulous + question marker])—

basically meaning “fabulous” and derived from the tag question “isn’t it fabulous?”—is frequently used to signal disapproval in the Hiwwhee usage. Under ironic contexts, the phrase implies that something is, in fact, not fabulous. Notably, when the response aligns with the speaker’s intended negative assessment, the word ไร้ดี or excellent may be elongated phonetically to sarcastically intensify disappointment, as noted by Sanitdee (2022). Similarly, (4) นี่ให้ (*nee hai* [this + grant]), which conventionally means “this is for you”, signaling permission, undergoes semantic inversion. Within the Hiwwhee discourse, it typically denotes something undesirable. For instance, in a severe traffic congestion, Erk comments: วันนี้อร่อยจริงๆ นี่ให้ (*wanni rot tit ching na ni hai*) “The traffic is really bad today. I rate it [one of the worst days]—นี่ให้ (or, in this particular context “I awarded it the worst traffic”). Here, “นี่ให้” functions evaluatively, marking the situation as frustrating.

1.3 Semantic Broadening

Beyond ironic reversal, semantic shift in this variety may also involve generalization—where originally specific meanings extend to broader contexts. This process illustrates the dynamic nature of lexical innovation within queer vernacular Thai. In certain cases, the Hiwwhee slang demonstrates semantic broadening, where domain-specific meanings are extended to encompass a wider range of comparable contexts. A prominent example is the term (5) ฉ่ำ (*cham*), which traditionally denotes “moist” or “hydrated” qualities, particularly in reference to food. In its extended, metaphorical use, ฉ่ำ functions as an evaluative predicate indicating intensity, excess, or unexpected satisfaction. It now applies across diverse domains—ranging from taste and texture to emotional or aesthetic experiences—implying richness, delight, or indulgence. Consider the following excerpt:

5a) Mix: กินเป็นหรือ หอยโข่งอะ

kin pen ro hoikhong a

(eat be Q escargot PART)

Can you eat escargot?

5b) Fahlada: ฉ่ำ ขมวดหมด

cham khamuat mot

(juicy coil all)

Totally juicy and delicious—wrapped it all up.

(Chaleomsri, 2024)

In this context, ฉ่ำ signals more than just physical taste; it signals an affective response of gratification, extending its scope to include sensory, emotional, and even social satisfaction. The phrase exemplifies both semantic broadening and expressive intensification.

Next, the Thai verb (6) สะตุ้ง (*sa-dung*), traditionally meaning “to be startled” or “to flinch in fear,” has undergone semantic shift and pragmatic refunctionalization in the Hiwwhee slang. It now conveys the meaning of performing exceptionally well or exceeding expectations. Originally used as an action verb, this word has been reshaped through semantic broadening and conversion to take on multiple roles—functioning adjectivally, adverbially, and as an interjection, expanding its syntactic and pragmatic scope. Consider the following excerpt:

6) Aclair: เราสั่ง[ของ]เป็นตันๆ ไง ก็เลยเป็นที่มาว่ายังหา ซัพพลายเออร์+

rao sang [khong] pen tan tan ngai ko loei pen thima wa yang ha sapphlai oe

(we order [things] by the ton PART thus be origin that still find supplier

We order [them] by the ton, you see? That's why we still haven't found a supplier+
 +ที่อร่อยแบบนั้น ไม่ได้นะคะ ซึ่งถ้านางทำสะดุ้งแน่
thi aroi baep nan mai dai na kha sueng tha nang tham sa-dung nae
 that delicious like that NEG PART^{POL} that if she do startle surely
 +as good as that. If she can do it—it'll be startling for sure."

(Juepak Official, 2024)

Here, สะดุ้ง (*sa-dung* [startled]) functions as an emphatic evaluative marker, showing excellence. Its syntactic versatility and affective load exemplify both lexical innovation and morphosyntactic fluidity in queer Thai discourse. This phenomenon parallels the case of ขมวด (*khamuat*)—originally meaning “to gather” or “summarize” in the previous example—which, in the Hiwwhee usage, has been resemanticized to mean “to consume entirely” (e.g., food), again illustrating semantic generalization coupled with pragmatic shift.

Another example of semantic generalization in the Hiwwhee Gang slang is the phrase (7) กี่โมง (*kee-mong*), which traditionally functions as a temporal interrogative meaning “What time is it?”. Through pragmatic reassignment, however, it is now employed sarcastically to question the plausibility of a statement. In this context, it signals exaggerated disbelief in ironic skepticism, suggesting that the claim exceeds what can be realistically expected. Consider the following exchange:

- 7a) Nisa: หนูลูกอันนี้พลังบวกนะคะ
nu luk an nii phalang buak na kha
 (you child this energy positive PAR^{POL})
 My dear, this is positive energy.
- 7b) Alie: บวกกี่โมง
buak kii mong
 (positive what time)
 How positive, exactly?

(Hiwwhee Official, 2024)

Here, (8) บวกกี่โมง (*buak kii mong* [plus + what time]) sarcastically interrogates the authenticity of the “positive energy,” reframing an optimistic assertion as implausible. This usage reflects not only semantic broadening but also meaning layering, wherein conventional forms are repurposed to perform stance-taking and irony.

1.4 Semantic Limitation

In contrast to broadening, some Hiwwhee Gang slang demonstrates semantic narrowing or limitation, wherein a previously general term acquires a more specific meaning. The expression (9) เช็ครุ่น (*check roon*)—literally “school batch checking”—originally denotes the act of “checking one’s cohort or generation.” Composed of เช็ค (*check*), meaning “to check” or “verify,” and รุ่น (*roon*), meaning “cohort,” “year,” or “generation,” the compound has been semantically reanalyzed to refer specifically to inter-cohort violence or brawls, particularly in school settings between juniors and seniors. Its pragmatic use reflects heightened tension and performative rivalry across educational hierarchies. Consider the following instance:

9) นิสาคเคยเช็ครุ่นตบวิทุรกลางโรงอาหารมาแล้ว โดนเช็ครุ่นมาแล้ว

ni sa khoei chek roon top withun klang rong ahan ma laeo don chek roon ma laeo
(Nisa once check gen.s lap Witun middle cafeteria already PAS check generation already)

Nisa once fought with and hazed her senior, Vitun, in the cafeteria. She's been through a hazing fight.

(Nisamanee, 2025)

Here, เช็ครุ่น (*chek roon* [check + generation/ batch]) has evolved into a socially loaded, context-specific term for physical confrontation and hierarchical rituals.

1.5 Complex Semantic Shifting and Morphological Innovation

Beyond semantic shift alone, several Hiwwhee Gang slang terms demonstrate additional morphological and structural complexity. Such lexical innovations reflect both playful creativity and layered meaning-making. Notable examples include (10) กุกกีกุกกีม่า (*kukkik kukmam*), (11) เซะตุ้มเล้ง (*se-tum-leng*), and (12) เช็คเมล (*chek mail*). First, the expression กุกกีกุกกีม่า is an ideophonic reduplication used to describe small-scale or casual actions, particularly in the context of eating. While it may literally refer to light snacking, its metaphorical extension signifies any trivial or minimal activity. For example:

10) Mix: ขอให้เงินเข้าแบบไม่กุกกีกุกกีม่า

kho hai ngoen khao baep mai kukkik kukmam
(may money enter manner NEG trivial kuk eat)

May the money come in abundantly—not just in tiny amounts.

(Hiwwhee Official, 2024)

In this case, กุกกีกุกกีม่า (*kukkik kukmam*) functions as a playful euphemism for insufficiency, while also showing how semantic shift works alongside expressive reduplication, ideophones, and exaggerated meaning in this sociolinguistic variety. Interestingly, กุกกีกุกกีม่า (*kukkik kukmam*) consists of three distinct morphemes: กุกกีกูก (*'trivial'*), กูก (*onomatopoeic, resembling a chicken's cluck*), and ม่า (*'to eat'*). While these components have independent semantic values, they have not previously co-occurred as a single lexical unit. Although this new morphological blend is unconventional, parts of its original meaning can still be identified, making it possible to trace its etymological roots, while one part is almost unidentified.

The second complex semantically shifted term, เซะตุ้มเล้ง (*se tum leng*), denotes something undesirable, or chaotic. The first morpheme, เซะ (*se*), originates from Lu language (ภาษาลู)—a form of anti-language within LGBTQIA+ communities involving systematic phonological transformation of Thai lexical items to exclude outsiders (Nordquist, 2024)—and is derived from เละ (*le*), meaning 'messy'. The element ตุ่ม (*tum*) possibly references either เละตุ้มเป๊ะ (*le tum pe*), an idiomatic expression indicating extreme disorder, or the onomatopoeic ตุ่ม (*tum*), evoking an explosion sound symbolism “toom” in Thai, equivalent to “boom” or “bomb” in English. Lastly, เล้ง (*leng*) refers to a bony pork spine with minimal meat, metaphorically connoting inadequacy. The integrated phrase thus amplifies semantic negativity, as illustrated in the following usage:

11) Mix: ขอให้หิ้วเทปนี้ไม่เซะต๋มเล้งคะ
kho hai hio wi thep ni mai se tum leng kha
(may Hiwwhee tape this NEG se tum leng PAR^{POL})
I hope this Hiwwhee episode does not receive negative feedback or become messy.
(Hiwwhee Official, 2024)

Similar to กุกกิกกุกห่ม (kuk kik kuk mum), this coined term เซะต๋มเล้ง (se tum leng) exemplifies total semantic shift, where disparate morphemes are creatively combined into a new form. What renders this slang item particularly complex is its opaque etymology; without deliberate analysis, native Thai speakers may not be able to trace its lexical roots, as it does not transparently derive from the more recognizable term เละ (le), meaning ‘messy’ or ‘disordered’. Instead, the term evolves through several processes—such as changes in meaning, sound and word structure blending, and regional language influence—resulting in a playful but socially meaningful new expression.

The third opaque instance of semantic shift is the slang term (12) เช็คเมล (check+mail). In standard Thai usage, this English loanword denotes the act of checking one’s email. However, within LGBTQIA+ linguistic communities, particularly among the Hiwwhee Gang, เช็คเมล (chek mail) has acquired a new, metaphorical meaning: to check one’s breath upon waking as a daily routine oral hygiene check. Thus, when the Hiwwhee member “Lukmauy” asks whether someone has เช็คเมล, the intended meaning is whether they have “checked” their morning breath. Although the scope of meaning remains narrowly defined, the shift is significant, moving from the domain of digital correspondence to that of personal grooming. This also represents a pragmatic recontextualization within a specific sociolect.

Additional examples of slang derived from original Thai lexemes, yet assigned entirely new meanings, are presented in Table 3 below where equivalent Thai–English transcriptions are provided in parentheses, and original Thai meanings appear in square brackets.

Table 3 Opaque Semantically Shifted Slang

Standard Thai Words Adapted into the Hiwwhee Slang	New Meanings and Use in the Hiwwhee Gang
13) แอ้นระแนง (ann ra nang) [bend + slat = a curved slat panel]	sexual position that requires arching the back, or “doggy style”
14) ม้าน้ำ (mah-nam) [seahorse]	a well-built gay man with a protruding belly, resembling the shape of a seahorse
15) แตก (taek) [to break or make into small pieces]	used as an adjective or interjection to express emotions such as being extremely excited, shocked, surprised, or feeling that something is overwhelmingly amazing in an exaggerated manner with a sense of fun or humor
16) 29 มีนาคม (yisip kao mi na) [twenty-ninth of March—originally Aclair Juepak’s birthday, when extravagant celebrations are always held with artists and stars gathering]	stunning or monumental, used both for positive and negative situations

1.6 Transparent Semantically Shifted Slang

Unlike slang terms that require deep etymological knowledge and semantic decoding, certain Hiwwhee slang terms remain partially transparent, with meanings that are only subtly altered from their original Thai forms. For instance, (17) ท่วม (thuam) [to flood], which traditionally denotes an area submerged by water, has been semantically extended to

describe anything overwhelming—such as emotions, reactions, or situational intensity in an exaggerated way. This figurative usage typically conveys a playful yet hyperbolic tone, suggesting something is “too much to handle.” As exemplified in a Hiwwhee episode, when Aclair ordered an excessive amount of fried food for the group, a member remarked, “สั่งของทอดมาท่วมมากคะทุกคน” (*sang khong thot ma thuam mak kha thuk khon*) [The food was ordered as if it could flood everyone], humorously indicating excess using hyperbole. Similarly, phonological manipulation underlies the slang term รำมะนาย (*ram ma-nai*), a modified form of รำมะนาด (*ram ma-nad*) [a gum disease causing bad breath], and, also possibly, *rebana*, a traditional, one-sided drum used in southern Thailand and across Southeast Asia. By replacing the final /d/ with /y/, the altered form retains its core semantic reference while functioning as a covert linguistic strategy. Specifically, this modification—frequently used by Luk Muey, a Hiwwhee member—enables the speaker to allude to someone's bad breath without the addressee understanding the implication. Such alterations illustrate both the group's creativity and the pragmatic functions of in-group slang as a form of indirect social commentary, politeness and euphemism.

2. Lexical Internationalization

2.1 Borrowing

In the digital and AI-driven era, lexical borrowing has become increasingly common in Central Thai, and the Hiwwhee idiolect is no exception. This phenomenon reflects not only globalization but also localized recontextualization of foreign lexemes. Four loanwords—borrowed from English and Japanese—demonstrate how semantic shifts and phonological adaptation contribute to Thai Hiwwhee slang.

The first example is (18) ว้าวไฮ (*wow-high*), a compound formed from the English interjection “wow” and the adjective “high”, denoting elevated quality, mood, or excitement. In the Hiwwhee discourse, the two elements are combined repetitively, and function as an intensifier of positive experience. For instance, Aclair's promotional remark—“Don't forget, Mom [sis]. You can watch YouTube in a *wow-high* way like Éclair does! Just dial 7777797# and press call”—illustrates how the term is repurposed to connote a premium experience. Unlike in standard English, where wow and high are distinct, their fusion in Thai amplifies the degree of double positivity.

The second term, (19) แฟต (*fat*), is a direct English loanword but semantically reconfigured. Rather than referencing body weight, it denotes an exaggerated manner of speaking or acting. Used playfully, it reflects overt expressiveness, as in Fluk's comment: “รู้รึยังว่าใคร แม่แฟตคนเขาตูดออกว่าแม่แฟต” (*ru rue yang wa khrai mao faet khon khao du ok wa mao faet*), meaning “Do you know who gossips flamboyantly? Everyone can tell.”

Another further example is (20) ดอทคอม (*dot com*), a clipped form of เส่ร้อแดกดอทคอม (*se ro daek dot com*). This slang term critiques behavior that is attention-seeking or socially awkward. While “*dot com*” originally references internet domains, in the Hiwwhee usage, it characterizes someone trying too hard to stand out—often with counterproductive results. For example, “แกอย่าทำแบบนี้เนะมันดอทคอมมาก” (*kae ya tham baep ni na man dot khom mak*) translates to “Don't do this; it looks ridiculous.”

Finally, the Japanese phrase 元気ですか (*genki desu ka*) [How are you?] is reappropriated into เกิร์จ (*kreng*) (21) เกิร์จ (*kreng ki det ka*) through phonological adaptation. Specifically, an epenthetic /r/ is inserted to transform *genki* into *krengki*, aligning it with the Thai word เกิร์จ (*kreng*) [to feel tense or awkward]. This results in a humorous neologism denoting nervousness or social discomfort. When Aclair states, “อีฟลุคเกิร์จเกิร์จเกิร์จด้วย” (*i fluk kreng ki det ka duai*), she implies that Fluk appeared uneasy.

These cases collectively illustrate how loanwords are not merely adopted but are systematically altered—phonologically, morphologically, and semantically—into markers of in-group identity and humor within the Hiwwhee sociolectal practices.

2.2 Clipping

Clipping, or word shortening, is often employed to enhance phonotactic compatibility with Thai speech patterns. This phenomenon occurs even with loanwords, particularly from English, where multisyllabic forms are reduced to more manageable segments. Three examples include clipped forms of English words “glamorous”, “Gatsby”, and “paranoid”. First, the slang (22) แกลม (*klaem*) results from apocope—the omission of the final two syllables /-mə.rəs/ from “glamorous”. Although phonetically reduced, the term retains its original semantic features, describing someone with exceptional beauty or flawless presentation. Within LGBTQIA+ and the Hiwwhee discourse, it often intensifies into the idiomatic phrase ติดแกลม (*tit klaem*) [addicted to glamour]. This is further demonstrated through linguistic play by Lukmauy, who humorously connected แกลม (*klaem*) with กรรมกร (*kammakon*) [laborer] due to their phonetic similarity, exclaiming: “แกลมมาก... แกลม-มา-กร” (*klaem mak... klaem ma kon*), meaning “You’re glam... ‘gam-mer,’” blending prestige and labor-class identity in jest mockingly. “แกลม” is commonly realized and orthographically represented as “แกลม,” indicating a phonological substitution of the lateral /l/ with the alveolar trill /r/ in Standard Thai.

Second, the term (23) แก๊ส (*kaet*) is a shortened version of the word Gatsby, with the final syllable /-sbil/ removed. While Gatsby in Western culture connotes opulence and vintage chic, in the Hiwwhee usage, แก๊ส describes outdated or elderly-looking fashion. This semantic shift is illustrated in the exchange: “แต่งตัวแก๊ส” (*taeng tua kae a*) [Your outfit looks outdated.], to which Lukmauy responds, “แก๊สมากวันนี้” (*kaet mak wanni*), Gas “old” style today—signaling a humorous critique of someone's retro unfashionable appearance.

Conversely, the slang (24) นอยด์ (*noid*) derives from the final syllable of paranoid, via aphaeresis, where the initial syllables /pe/ and /rə/ are omitted. Although morphologically shortened, นอยด์ (-noid) still conveys strong emotional meanings related to anxiety or heightened sensitivity. In LGBTQIA+ usage, it articulates nuanced emotional states in a non-clinical, socially embedded register, encapsulating collective experiences of stress or overthinking in a light, relatable manner.

All in all, these clipped forms demonstrate how Hiwwhee speakers creatively appropriate and phonologically reshape loanwords while imbuing them with culturally specific meanings, contributing to a dynamic lexicon of Thai LGBTQIA+ expression.

2.3 Compounding

In the Hiwwhee slang, compounding—the morphological process of combining multiple lexical items—often involves Thai and foreign morphemes to intensify meaning or introduce new pragmatic functions. This results in hybridized expressions that are both semantically rich and culturally specific. A representative example is (25) ดิ่งดาวน์ (*ding down*), a two-part compound phrase that metaphorically conveys a sense of emotional downturn or distress. The Thai verb ดิ่ง (*ding*), meaning ‘to plunge’ is combined with the English adjective “down”, denoting a negative or low state. Together, they form a redundant yet emphatic construction, vividly evoking a deep emotional descent. In contrast, the syntactically elaborate compound (26) จิ้งมารูอึ้งแบบต๊าซ (*jung maru ueng baep tach*) is formed through a totally different linguistic mechanism. Here, จิ้ง (*jung*)—an ideophone evoking shock or awe—derives from the sound-symbolic form of อึ้ง (*ueng*), meaning ‘speechless’ or ‘stunned’. The morpheme มารู (*maru*) functions as a word filler, adding rhythmic balance and aesthetic appeal without carrying any clear meaning. It is present in expressions like อีสมารูอ้วย (*is maru uai*) and คิตตี้มารูอึ้ง (*kitty maru i*), where sound play enhances performativity. The final constituent, (27) ต๊าซ (*tach*), is a neologism

meaning ‘fabulous’ or ‘extraordinary.’ Originally emerging from the sound effect used in the Miss Eco International beauty pageant, it was popularized by Brian Tan, a renowned pageant recap influencer and founder of Miss Fabulous Thailand. As a whole, จึ้งมารู้อึ้งแบบตาช (jung maru ueng baep tach) encapsulates an exuberant emotional reaction—akin to being spectacularly dazzled—with heightened dramatic flair. Again, such compounds exemplify how the Hiwwhee sociolect not only repurposes words across languages but also innovates with prosodic and playful structures.

2.4 Conversion

More structurally complex than semantic shift, conversion—the change in a word’s grammatical or lexical category without affixation—plays a significant role in the Hiwwhee slang. This process often involves both functional and semantic transformation, whereby nouns or verbs are repurposed as adjectives or adverbs, accompanied by shifts in connotation and usage context. A good example is the term (28) อ่อม (aom), traditionally a noun in Central Thai referring to a type of vegetable curry, or a verb in Lao language and Isan dialect meaning ‘to cook vegetable curry.’ In the Hiwwhee usage, however, อ่อม (aom) is converted into an adjective or adverb. Its semantic value is drastically redefined: rather than denoting an appetizing dish, it conveys boredom, dullness, or aesthetic unpleasantness. Specifically, it can describe an outdated or deteriorated appearance—such as makeup that has faded, melted, or become oily. The term frequently carries humorous or sarcastic overtones when applied to unexciting events, uninspired behaviors, or unattractive visuals. This usage is exemplified in Éclair’s song ขอคนไม่เล่น (kho khon mai len), where the line “ฟังแล้วมันเมื่อย มันอ่อม มันอ่อม” (fang laeo man mueai man aom man aom) translates as “Listening to it is tiring—so dull, so dull.” Metaphorically, the visual quality of the curry—overcooked vegetables simmered to the point of appearing lifeless—may inspire the slang’s negative aesthetic associations, despite its savory taste. Another instance of conversion is found in (29) เซรั่มนารา (serum nara), originally coined as the name of a skincare product by Nara, a Hiwwhee member. While initially a proper noun and commercial label, the term is now employed adjectivally and interjectionally to express admiration or brilliance—detached from its cosmetic origins. As Nara’s visibly improved complexion garnered public attention, her product’s name evolved into a compliment, used across contexts. For instance, “Your outfit is so serum-nara!” or “You’re totally rocking that serum-nara look!” Such usage illustrates how commercial branding can undergo lexical conversion, serving as an evaluative marker within queer morphological creativity.

In summary, these lexical internationalization cases demonstrate how the Hiwwhee speakers skillfully manipulate grammatical categories to generate expressive, contextually rich, and often humorous meanings—highlighting the dynamic interplay between form, function, and identity in LGBTQIA+ discourse in the globalized digital era.

3. Cultural Adaptations

3.1 Coinage

Among the earliest word-formation processes in any language, coinage is defined as the creation of entirely new lexical items through arbitrary sound combinations, independent of existing lexical roots. Such neologisms often consist of phonologically connected yet semantically opaque units, forming either monosyllabic or multisyllabic structures. While true coinage is rare in modern usage, especially in languages with rich etymological histories like Thai, certain contemporary slang expressions still exemplify this process. In the present corpus, only two tokens qualify as pure coinages, as most other neologisms show traceable etymological links to Standard Central Thai. The first example is (30) “โห้ะ” (so), a slang term conveying playful encouragement, comparable to the English “go for it,” often delivered with humorous or teasing undertones. Depending on context, “โห้ะ” (so) may imply something unusual, amusing, or aesthetically striking.

30) Nisa: โห้! ลง ไป เลย
 So long pai loei
 (So down go PAR^{ALLOW})
 Go for it!

(Hiwwhee Official, 2025)

The second coinage, (31) PPY, is an acronym for พี่ผู้ชายใหญ่ (*Pee Phu Yai*), denotes a physically attractive, older, often financially supportive male "sugar daddy" figure—used playfully within LGBTQIA+ discourse. Notably, PPY did not exist in the Thai lexicon prior to its emergence in digital media slang:

31) Mix: ถ้าสมมุติว่าผู้ชายใหญ่น่ารักินหนูจะเรียก PPY ตัวย่อ
tha sommut wa phuyai nakin nu cha riak PPY tua yo
 (if suppose that ad looks tasty I will call PPY letter contraction)
 If men appear handsome and attractive, I refer to them as PPY for short.

(Thairath Variety, 2024)

Importantly, PPY also demonstrates compounding and borrowing, as it appropriates the phonetic value of English alphabetic syllables while applying them within a Thai sociocultural frame. The transliteration of English letter sounds to form a Thai slang term exemplifies a transliteration-based coinage, favored among Thai speakers for its playful mimicry and style. This blending of English phonology and Thai semantics fosters a humorous, sometimes satirical tone, deviating from the conventional prosodic patterns of Thai speech.

3.2 Onomatopoeia

Onomatopoeia, the process by which words phonetically imitate natural sounds, is a productive word-formation strategy in Thai slang. Traditionally, the term (32) “โห้ง (*hong*)” mimics the sound of a dog's bark, equivalent to the English “woof”. However, in the Hiwwhee usage, it undergoes semantic extension, now serving as an expressive slang term connoting something visually striking. For instance, when Mix exclaims: “อู๊ย ผมโคตรโห้งเลยวะ (*ui phom khot hong ley wa*), —she repurposes the original sound-symbolic value to convey personal admiration, marking a shift from iconic representation to evaluative metaphor. A comparable example is (33) “ปังมาก (*pang mak*)”, a compound expression denoting high praise. The root “ปัง (*pang*)” [bang], widely used in Thai LGBTQIA+ communities, functions as an adjective meaning “excellent”. Though its etymology is debated, it is likely influenced by the English onomatopoeic “bang”, which suggests a sudden, powerful impact. In Thai, “ปัง” (*pang*) similarly evokes the idea of an impressive event or outcome, reinforced in the emphatic collocation “ปังมาก” (*pang mak*), “extremely impressive.” It is noteworthy that “ปัง (*pang*)” also exists as a verbal onomatopoeia in Thai, mimicking the sound of a gunshot. Thus, its figurative use in slang reflects a layered interplay between phonosemantic motivation and pragmatic recontextualization, transforming literal sound-imitating forms into symbolic markers of admiration.

3.3 Euphemism

While some linguists classify euphemism as a subtype of semantic shift rather than a distinct word-formation process, certain complex slang constructions merit independent analysis. A notable example is (34) “คิตตี้ มารู้อี้ (*kitty ma ru i*)”, a euphemistic expression coined by the Hiwwhee to refer playfully to diarrhea or stomach discomfort. This term integrates phonological substitution, semantic extension, blending, and compounding, justifying its classification as a multi-process construction. The base word “คิตตี้ (*kitty*)” phonetically echoes the Thai vulgar term “ขี้” (*khi*) [feces], or “ปวดขี้”

(*puat khi*) [to feel the urge to defecate]. By substituting “*กึ๋น*” (*khi*) with the phonetically similar and culturally sanitized “kitty”—a reference to the Japanese cartoon character Hello Kitty, widely popular among Thai adolescents in the 1990s—the slang user softens the otherwise crude connotation. The playful suffix *-ty* further phonologically foreignize the word, aligning it with Japanese-sounding, *kawaii* cute-style expressions to enhance its socially acceptable tone. Finally, the coined term incorporates “*มารู*” (*maru*), a filler word previously discussed, used here to enhance rhythm, prosody, and semantic vagueness. The final */i/* sound contributes to its phonological cohesion, completing the construction “*กิตตี้ มารูอิ*” (*kitty ma ru i*)” as a euphemistic alternative for taboo functions. This strategic avoidance of direct reference to undesirable or private topics serves the pragmatic function of euphemism in informal Thai discourse.

Note: Some slang words are dual-formed due to their derivation from double word-formation processes while many are multi-categorical, reflecting their classification under several linguistic mechanisms.

4. Identity Construction

The findings of this study reveal that the slang used by the Hiwwee Gang serves diverse linguistic and sociocultural functions, encapsulating themes of self-expression, group identity, humor, aesthetics, critique, and commercialization. These expressions transcend informal speech, functioning as culturally embedded linguistic tools within Thailand's LGBTQIA+ community. Many of the analyzed slang terms act as identity markers, enabling speakers to articulate lived experiences through stylized, context-specific language. Importantly, the playful and performative nature of these terms highlights how language in LGBTQIA+ discourse serves multiple functions. It operates as a means of communication while also expressing identity and reinforcing group belonging. Building on Halliday's (1976) notion of anti-language, this study views LGBTQIA+ slang as a group-specific linguistic system that actively reshapes meaning within a marginalized community. Halliday emphasizes that anti-language reconstructs social reality through relexicalization rather than merely describing it. From this perspective, the repeated use of LGBTQIA+ slang functions as a performative speech act, as it enacts group membership and identity through use. Thus, such linguistic practices serve not only communicative purposes but also performatively sustain community identity in digital spaces. This corresponds with Jannah (2023), who characterized slang as an adaptive linguistic feature that consolidates identity and solidarity. However, while Jannah's study focuses on teenage dialogue in *Mean Girls*, the present study highlights a more dynamic mechanism: the active role of LGBTQIA+ influencers in co-constructing slang via real digital platforms, resulting in a highly interactive and rapidly evolving linguistic ecosystem.

Additionally, the affective dimension of slang, as emphasized by Ryanto (2022), is clearly evident in the Hiwwee Gang's lexicon. Their language fosters emotional intimacy and collective understanding, enabling users to navigate social encounters while simultaneously expressing emotion and solidarity. From a structural perspective, a defining feature of this slang is its innovative use of word-formation processes. The data reveals that semantic shift, borrowing, and clipping are the dominant mechanisms. This finding contrasts with earlier research (e.g., Wan Mohd Muzani & Mohammad Lotfie, 2024; Yahya & Ardi, 2023), which highlights a wider use of backformation, acronyms, and derivational processes in slang formation. These processes were not clearly evident in the current dataset. Instead, Thai LGBTQIA+ slang here tends to favor flexible word use, playful sounds, and creative reinterpretation of familiar terms. This supports Kanchanabundhu & Trakulkasemsuk (2022), who noted that Thai LGBTQIA+ speakers commonly use meaning-shift strategies to add humor and express identity in daily communication. Similarly, Unthanon, Chanthao, and Dandee (2024) reinforce the role of semantic innovation and playful lexical manipulation in Thai neologisms. Moreover, phonological modifications emerge as a basic feature of this morphological creativity, significantly contributing to broader language variation and evolution. As observed by Sanitdee (2022), such sound-based alterations shape not only slang but also mainstream Thai linguistic practices. Therefore, these semantic and phonological innovations not only reflect sociolinguistic dynamics but also

function as tools for in-group identification, cultural creativity, and indicators of societal openness. When widely adopted, these slang terms become embedded in popular discourse and culture, influencing both form and meaning across linguistic registers.

4.1 Lexical Categories and Functions

Word classes play key roles in shaping the unique communicative style of the Hiwwhee Gang and their audience. Nouns such as PPY (พี่ผู้ใหญ่ [*pee phu yai*]), often function as social labels, helping to express identity and foster group belonging. Verbs like เช็คเมล (check mail) are frequently reinterpreted through conversion, gaining new, community-specific meanings. Likewise, ที่โมง (kee-mong), usually used to ask about time, is creatively reimagined to call out exaggeration or questionable claims, demonstrating the group's use of irony and semantic shift. Adjectives are mainly employed for emphasis or exaggeration, especially in describing beauty, status, or emotional impact, as seen in expressions like เซรั่มนารา (*serum nara*), แพนต (fat), and ปังมาก (*pang mak*), all used to describe something impressive. These findings align with Ma (2018), who highlights how onomatopoeic and stylistically playful modifications enrich informal communication. Furthermore, they parallel with Williams (2024), who illustrates how pidgin and jargon serve identity-reinforcing functions, a dynamic similarly observed in Thai LGBTQIA+ slang.

Beyond grammatical classification, this study brings to light the broader sociolinguistic functions of the Hiwwhee Gang's slang. Above all, it plays a key role in affirming LGBTQIA+ identity and strengthening group cohesion. These distinctive and culturally embedded expressions act as an "insider language," fostering solidarity and shared understanding. Additionally, such slang supports emotional expression and well-being. Humor and exaggeration often help users cope with personal difficulties in a more light-hearted, less stigmatized way. For instance, ดิ่งตาวน (ding down) is a casual euphemism for sadness or depression, while ชีวิตแลกชีวิต (*chee vit leak chee vit*), meaning "life for life," expresses strong emotional bonds and loyalty in friendships. These findings support Ryanto's (2022) view that slang promotes emotional closeness, especially through performative and exaggerated speech. They also resonate with Allan & Burrige's (2006) assertion that slang reinforces social connection. Thus, the Hiwwhee Gang's slang serves not only as a form of communication, but also as a tool for identity building, emotional support, and cultural expression.

4.2 Humor, Criticism, and Beauty Standards

Another key finding of this study is the complex interplay of humor, beauty ideals, and social critique within the Hiwwhee Gang's slang. Many of their expressions rely on playful exaggeration to add energy to conversation. For instance, จิ้งมารู้อึงแบบบ๊าซ (*jung maru oong bab touch*) functions as a performative intensifier, used to describe something exceptionally impressive while highlighting the community's bold and flamboyant style. At the same time, several terms subtly or overtly carry social commentary. Sarcasm and irony often serve as indirect tools to critique behaviors, trends, or unrealistic beauty standards. For example, เร็ดปะ (*rerd pa*) is frequently used with ironic tone to question the authenticity of something perceived as showy or excessive.

These examples show that LGBTQIA+ slang serves not only expressive purposes but also evaluative and discursive ones, allowing users to challenge social norms through humor and morphological creativity. The theme of beauty is particularly prominent, with terms like โห้ง (*hong*) and แกลม (*glam*) representing luxury and attractiveness. These words often undergo semantic extension and pragmatic recontextualization, turning ordinary language into stylized commentary. While Sanitdee (2023) highlighted phonological and semantic shifts in Thai LGBTQIA+ slang, this study builds on that by showing how beauty-related expressions function both as aspirational markers and as tools for parody. Consistent with Allan & Burrige's (2006) view that slang serves as a means of humor and resistance, expressions like เร็ดปะ (*rerd pa*) and ที่โมง (*kee-mong*) reveal how irony and ambiguity allow for subtle social critique. Overall, these slang terms enhance communicative style while enabling speakers to resist norms and engage in cultural commentary.

5. Slang Circulation: Cultural Capital and Commercialization

The increasing presence of Thai LGBTQIA+ slang in mainstream media and marketing reflects its rising commercialization and socio-economic value. Businesses, influencers, and content creators are increasingly leveraging these expressions to appeal to younger and more diverse audiences. What once served as in-group language has now become a marketable cultural asset. For example, ปังมาก (*pang mak*), originally used to express admiration, is now commonly featured in beauty and fashion campaigns to signal desirability and trendiness, as commonly seen in TV commercials and advertising signposts. Similarly, เซรั่มนารา (*serum nara*), once a product name, has expanded in meaning to describe anything perceived as flawless or luxurious. This shift from brand name to widely used slang reflects how commercial branding can influence language adoption and cultural relevance.

These findings echo Kopaczyk (2014), who emphasized the role of digital media in accelerating the spread of slang, and Rezeki & Sagala (2019), who described slang as a product of informal, media-driven discourse. In the Thai context, LGBTQIA+ slang spreads rapidly via platforms like YouTube, Facebook, X, TikTok, and Instagram, where it is not only adopted but also creatively reinterpreted. Popular terms such as จิ้ง (*jung*) and ตำซำ (*touch*) exemplify this trend. Building on Wihadi, Pratiwi, and Rahmatunnisa (2020), this study shows that in Thailand, commercialization contributes to both the functional expansion and lexical innovation of LGBTQIA+ slang. The Hiwwhee Gang's vocabulary has extended beyond its original subcultural use, entering mainstream advertising, influencer content, and even everyday speech among non-LGBTQIA+ communities.

In addition, the popularity of certain slang expressions shows how strongly they connect with the culture. Words like ดิ่งดาวน์ (*ding down*) and อ่อม (*aom*) have been featured in popular music—for example, Ding Down by Alie Blackcobra and Aom by Aclair. These songs demonstrate how slang can transfer into other forms of media, adding symbolic and emotional depth. Remarkably, Ding Down has accumulated over 13 million views on YouTube within 8 months after its release, reflecting the widespread appeal and cultural vitality of LGBTQIA+ slang in Thai popular culture. Further, annual concerts and events organized by the Hiwwhee Gang generate over 10 million baht in revenue, contributing significantly to the growth of the LGBTQIA+ economy, not including the beauty products and merchandise created and sold by the group's members. Evidently, the LGBTQIA+ idiolect—commonly referred to as *kathoey* (ladyboy) language—has increasingly permeated standard Thai. This is reflected in the rising popularity of word-guessing games and fill-in-the-blank live quizzes featuring widely used *kathoey* slang and expressions on mainstream media platforms. Apparently, such content is often adopted by heterosexual men to boost engagement and visibility on social media. Ultimately, *kathoey* language may function as a form of soft power that draws the interest of international audiences. For those seeking to learn Thai within real-life, contemporary, or pop culture contexts, familiarity with slang and Thai queer culture can serve as both an effective icebreaker and a means of fostering group enjoyment as well.

In sum, Thai LGBTQIA+ slang has moved beyond its niche origins, becoming a dynamic and influential linguistic resource that connects language, identity, and the economy in today's digital media landscape.

Conclusion and Suggestions

This study demonstrates that the Hiwwhee Gang's linguistic practices reflect a high degree of morphological creativity, characterized by processes such as semantic shift, borrowing, clipping, compounding, and ideophonic innovation. The 34 analyzed slang terms show how Thai LGBTQIA+ speakers strategically manipulate language to construct identity, express emotion, foster social belonging, and challenge linguistic expectations. These findings highlight the dynamic interplay between digital media, sociocultural identity, and lexical innovation, underscoring the central role of

LGBTQIA+ influencers in shaping contemporary Thai discourse. Overall, the study affirms that queer morphological creativity is not only stylistic but also performative and culturally significant, contributing to broader patterns of language change in Thailand's digital era.

Future research should expand beyond a single influencer collective to compare linguistic practices across different LGBTQIA+ communities, media platforms, or regional contexts. Additionally, researchers may consider incorporating audience reception studies to examine how non-LGBTQIA+ viewers interpret and adopt queer slang, thereby extending insights into language diffusion and sociocultural impact. Longitudinal studies would also be valuable for tracing how slang evolves over time, particularly in response to shifting social attitudes and digital trends. Finally, integrating quantitative corpus-based methods could complement qualitative insights and provide a more comprehensive understanding of the frequency, variation, and circulation of LGBTQIA+ linguistic innovations in Thai popular culture.

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